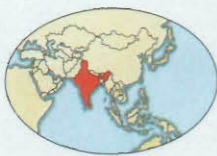


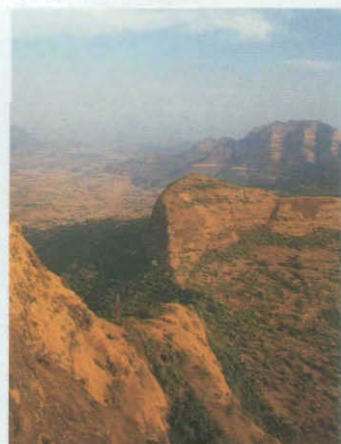
INDIA AND SRI LANKA



SEPARATED FROM other Asian countries by the Himalayas in the north, India forms part of a subcontinent that also includes Pakistan, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Nepal, and the island of Sri Lanka, which lies 32 km (20 miles) to the south. India is the world's seventh largest and second most populated country. Poverty is a serious problem, but India is self-sufficient in food production and increasingly industrialized, counting among the world's largest economies.

Physical features

The Himalayan peaks form a natural border in northeastern India. The Indo-Gangetic Plain is drained by the Ganges and Indus rivers and stretches from Pakistan to Bangladesh. The Thar Desert is on the Pakistan border. The peninsula land slopes west from the Western Ghats across the Deccan Plateau to the Bay of Bengal.



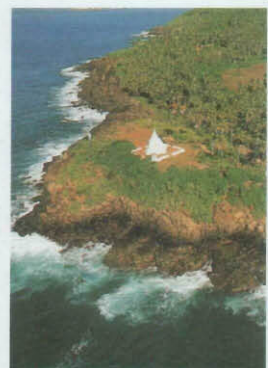
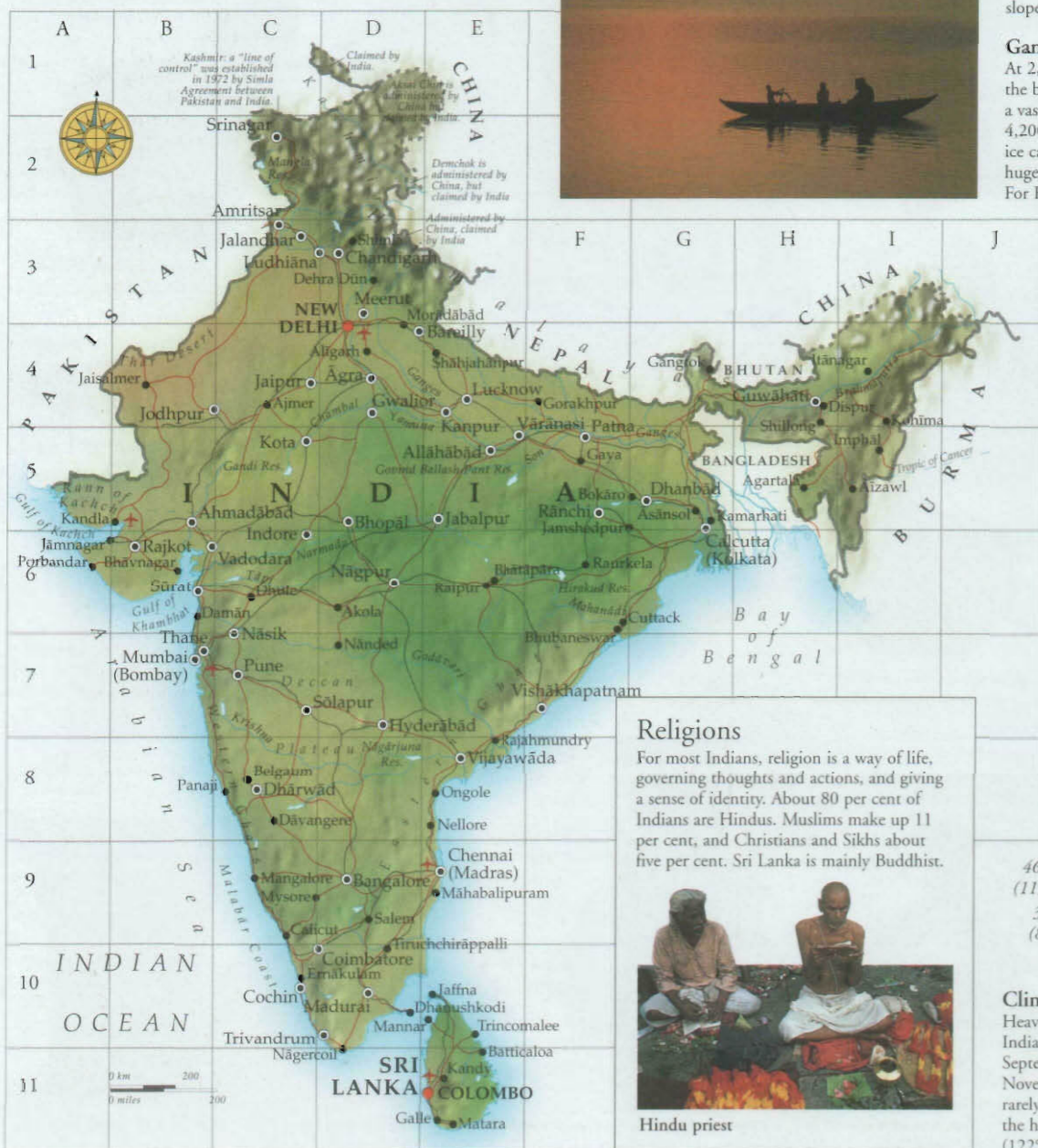
Western Ghats

The Western Ghats mountains stretch along India's west coast, rising to a height of 2,695 m (8,842 ft). Forests of tropical palms cover the lowlands west of the mountains, and lush, evergreen rainforest, home to tigers and elephants, cloaks the slopes. To the east is dry, deciduous forest.



Ganges

At 2,700 km (1,678 miles) the Ganges is the biggest river in India, flowing through a vast, highly populated plain. Its source is 4,200 m (13,779 ft) above sea-level in an ice cave in the Himalayas. It ends in a huge delta that is mostly in Bangladesh. For Hindus, the Ganges is a sacred river.



Sri Lanka

Just off the southeastern tip of India lies the island of Sri Lanka, which is a country in its own right. At the centre of the island are high mountains surrounded by a low coastal plain. Like southern India, Sri Lanka has a tropical climate with two monsoon seasons each year. However, the southwest has no dry season and is humid all year, while the northeast is drier, with open forest and grassland.

Religions

For most Indians, religion is a way of life, governing thoughts and actions, and giving a sense of identity. About 80 per cent of Indians are Hindus. Muslims make up 11 per cent, and Christians and Sikhs about five per cent. Sri Lanka is mainly Buddhist.



Hindu priest



Climate

Heavy and persistent monsoon rains soak India and Sri Lanka between June and September. The coolest season is from November to March. Winter temperatures rarely fall below 20°C (68°F) except in the high Himalayas, and may top 50°C (122°F) on northern plains in summer.